

HAVEN · RESEARCH & DEVELOPMENT

Haven and Dhofar's Ocean Culture

A strategic study for a living maritime-cultural destination at Osara,
Raysut

**A contemporary Dhofari coastal majlis where the Indian Ocean's
routes, people and stories are encountered through hospitality.**

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Strategic research paper · Not a heritage designation or approved development plan

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Executive judgement

Haven has a credible opportunity to become more than a beachfront coffee shop, but the opportunity is not best described as a “frankincense theme.” Dhofar’s ports were interfaces: between mountain and sea, local and newcomer, Arabia and the wider Indian Ocean, free movement and forced movement, old settlement and new technology. Haven can continue that culture by becoming a **small living port of encounter**—a hospitable place where residents, fishers, port workers, craftspeople, scholars, travellers and present-day migrant communities can meet and interpret the coast together.

The location makes the proposition unusually strong. Haven is at Osara on Raysut Beach, close to the modern Port of Salalah and the redeveloping Raysut fishing harbour. The coast therefore holds ancient maritime memory, a living fishing economy, contemporary global shipping and a new leisure destination within one landscape. Port of Salalah itself presents Dhofar as a historic connector of Rome, Arabia, Egypt, Persia, East Africa and India, while its modern terminal has handled more than 50 million TEU since 1998. The old function has not vanished; its machinery and social form have changed. [Port of Salalah, “Our Story”](#)

The recommended proposition is:

Haven: The Living Port — a contemporary Dhofari coastal majlis where the Indian Ocean's routes, people and stories are encountered through hospitality.

This should remain a good café first. Culture should make the visit deeper and more memorable, not make service slower or turn the room into a static museum. A six-month, scholar- and community-reviewed pilot is more credible than a large themed fit-out.

1. The historical picture: ports as social machinery

1.1 The ocean was a road with a timetable

The Indian Ocean monsoon did more than move merchandise. Its seasonally reversing winds caused ships and people to arrive, wait, repair, negotiate, worship, eat and sometimes remain until the next sailing window. Ports were therefore not simple loading points. They were temporary homes and places where commercial trust, translation and shared practices developed. Roxani Eleni Margariti’s study of medieval Aden shows how monsoon rhythms, water, harbour infrastructure, administration and socially embedded merchant networks together made a port-city. Dhofar sat on the same navigational system, between the Gulf of Aden, Red Sea, East Africa, Persian Gulf and India. [Princeton University, Aden and the Indian Ocean Trade](#)

The sea was only half the system. Frankincense moved from trees and inland collection areas through settlements and caravan routes to coastal ports. Research on al-Baleed notes journeys of about 16 days to Hadramawt, a month to Aden and 20 days to northern Oman; goods also crossed the Empty Quarter toward eastern Arabia and southern Iraq. Dhofar’s port culture was therefore produced by mountain pastoralists and cultivators, caravan handlers, town merchants, sailors, fishers and foreign buyers—not by sailors alone. [Newton and Zarins, Dhofar Through the Ages](#)

1.2 Indigenous Dhofar before and beside the foreign port

It is important not to begin the story with outsiders “discovering” an empty coast. Work at al-Hamr al-Sharqiyah 1 (HAS1), on the Inqitat promontory by Khor Rori, identifies a previously unrecognised **Dhofar Coastal Culture**, with occupation from roughly the eighth–seventh centuries BCE into the first–second centuries CE. It partly overlapped with Sumhuram. The evidence is still developing, but it establishes an indigenous social and economic base alongside the better-known South Arabian foundation. [Silvia Lischi, “A First Definition of the Dhofar Coastal Culture”](#)

That changes the interpretation. The formative event was not merely “international trade reached Dhofar.” It was an encounter between existing Dhofari populations and a Hadrami political-commercial project, with exchange extending between coast and interior. Recent investigation at Andhur similarly describes Hadrami engagement with Dhofari

populations as a complex system of cultural interactions rather than a one-way transfer. [Lischi et al., "The Easternmost Outpost of the Hadramawt Kingdom"](#)

1.3 Sumhuram/Khor Rori: a founded town that became cosmopolitan

Between the end of the third and beginning of the second century BCE, the kingdom of Hadramawt established Sumhuram, more than 700 km from its capital Shabwa, probably to organise access to Dhofar's frankincense. It was a fortified town beside a freshwater khor and a maritime route linking the Red Sea and Mediterranean-facing networks with India and the Gulf. Its occupation continued into approximately the fifth century CE. [Zampierin et al., Archaeometry](#)

The material evidence is more useful than a generic claim of "global trade":

- Pottery analysis identifies production groups from southwestern Arabia and the Indian subcontinent.
- Research on materials from excavations has advanced the hypothesis that people from India were present, not merely Indian goods.
- A north-west Indian etched-carnelian bead may have been merchandise or a South Asian resident's personal possession; the authors explicitly leave both possibilities open.
- The nearby indigenous HAS1 settlement demonstrates that Sumhuram was not the only society in the landscape.

Together these finds support mobility, repeated contact and cultural entanglement. They do **not** prove that every imported object belonged to a settled foreign community, or allow a simple ethnic census of an ancient town. [University of Pisa, "Traces of an Indian Community in the city of Sumhuram"; Frenez and Lischi, 2026](#)

1.4 Al-Baleed/Zafar: the medieval city between land and sea

Al-Baleed, the medieval Zafar, succeeded Khor Rori as Dhofar's great Islamic port city. The strongest phases in the published chronology include Habudhi rule (c. 950–1279), Rasulid invasion and occupation (1279–1420), and later Kathiri influence. Customs revenue tied the city to the Rasulid government in Aden and Taizz. [Newton and Zarins, Dhofar Through the Ages](#)

Its exchange system was broader than frankincense. Historical and archaeological work records trade in aromatics, medicinal and dyestuff products, and Arabian horses. Marco Polo and Ibn Battuta described the profitable export of Dhofari horses to India. Excavated objects and ceramics connect al-Baleed with Yemen, Iran, the Indian subcontinent, China and East Africa. Alexia Pavan's study appropriately calls the city a place of "trade, exchange, diversity, and coexistence," while also noting that the quantity and meaning of evidence varies by period. [Pavan, "The Islamic Port of al-Balid"; UNESCO, Land of Frankincense](#)

This was an urban culture made by taxation and government, warehouses and mosques, wells and walls, artisans and domestic life as well as ships. For Haven, that is a vital lesson: a meaningful port concept needs social practices, not just maps and model dhows.

1.5 Mirbat and the chain of smaller harbours

Dhofar never depended on only one port. Mirbat's sheltered beach served as its traditional port and an entrepôt connecting Indian Ocean and Gulf markets with the frankincense interior. Its historic fabric demonstrates how a working coastal settlement could combine trade, residence, religious life and regional exchange. [ArCHIAM, Mirbat Heritage Management Plan](#)

Taqah, Sadah, Hasik, Rakhyut and the Hallaniyat coast belong in the wider story as fishing, anchorage and regional movement points, even where their documentary or archaeological record is thinner. It is better to present them as a **network with different levels of evidence** than to make every cove an "ancient international port." Current investment in fishing facilities at Raysut, Mirbat, Sadah, Rakhyut and al-Hallaniyat also shows that the harbour network remains economically alive. [Oman News Agency, Raysut fishing port update](#)

1.6 The connected Omani–Yemeni coast

Modern borders should not be projected backwards as cultural walls. Dhofar was closely connected to al-Mahra and Hadramawt. Qana in present-day Yemen was Hadramawt's principal ancient port: excavations recovered Greek texts, African and Mediterranean pottery and material permitting its history to be traced into the early Islamic period. [A. V. Sedov, 1992](#)

Later, al-Shihr and Mukalla connected inland Hadrami towns to Africa, India and Southeast Asia. Hadrami migration did not create copies of one culture abroad. Engseng Ho describes descendants becoming local in India and Southeast Asia while retaining mobile genealogies and written connections; the Oxford “Converging Cultures” project notes the return flow of food, clothing, architecture and ideas into Hadramawt. [Engseng Ho, The Graves of Tarim; Oxford COMPAS, “Converging Cultures”](#)

Aden supplied the great western hinge to the Red Sea and Mediterranean. Socotra was another multilingual meeting point: inscriptions in Hoq Cave and other evidence record visitors from several Indian Ocean regions. These places make Dhofar legible as one node in a connected southern Arabian littoral, not an isolated source of incense.

1.7 Raysut: continuity with a discontinuity

Raysut had a small natural harbour and a fort, probably from the early sixteenth century. After 1970, an all-season harbour replaced offshore transfer at Salalah; the container terminal opened in 1998 and reinserted Raysut into the main Europe–Asia shipping route. Steffen Wippel describes this as the economic and spatial transformation of a globalised port city. [Wippel, “Salalah: Economic Development and Spatial Fragmentation”](#)

The continuity is global connection. The discontinuity is public experience. Containers move rapidly through secure infrastructure; visiting crews spend less time embedded in town; industrial and leisure space are separated. Haven can interpret that invisible connection without romanticising the industrial port. It can be a public threshold from which people understand why Raysut is both a local beach and a global maritime node.

2. People, settlement and the making of identity

Dhofar's social diversity cannot be reduced to a list of “foreign blood.” J. E. Peterson describes a small region with an unusually complex social mosaic. Arabic-speaking communities of the Salalah plain and Najd coexist with speakers of Modern South Arabian languages in mountain and border landscapes; occupation, territory, language, tribal affiliation and former status all shaped boundaries. Modern mobility and national development have blurred some distinctions. [J. E. Peterson, “Oman's Diverse Society: Southern Oman”](#)

The coast added further layers:

- **Hadrami and Mahri connections:** political foundations, trade, family movement and shared linguistic-cultural geography linked Dhofar to present-day Yemen.
- **Fishers and sailors:** coastal communities developed knowledge of beaches, winds, landing places, boats, preservation and markets; their knowledge is heritage even when it left few monumental remains.
- **South Asian presence:** ancient imported objects suggest contact and possible residence at Sumhuram; later and contemporary merchants and workers belong to different historical systems and must not be collapsed into one timeless “Indian community.”
- **African and Afro-Arab presence:** movement between Arabia and East Africa included sailors, merchants, religious networks, settlers and return migrants, but also enslavement and unequal status. Coastal Omani forms such as lewa show how East African and Baloch connections became locally authoritative tradition. [Sultan Qaboos University research summary, “Cosmopolitan Authenticity”](#)
- **Zanzibari return migration:** especially after 1970, Omanis returning from East Africa negotiated identities that were simultaneously Omani, Arab, Zanzibari and Swahili-influenced. This is a major national Omani story, though it should not be claimed as uniquely Dhofari. [Nafla S. Kharusi, “Identity and Belonging”](#)
- **Contemporary migrant residents:** South Asian, East African, Arab and other workers now sustain Salalah's port, hospitality, retail and service economies. They are not historical props; if included, they should speak in their own voices and be paid as present-day contributors.

Any public interpretation must acknowledge that ocean exchange produced both creativity and hierarchy. Slavery cannot be turned into a dramatic decorative chapter, and it cannot be erased in a story of harmonious cosmopolitanism. The appropriate initial form is a carefully researched conversation or oral-history project with qualified historians and affected communities—not an unreviewed wall panel.

3. What Haven can mean

The central metaphor

A haven is a protected place of arrival and pause. A khor or harbour does similar cultural work: it makes encounter possible. The brand name can therefore acquire a local, intelligible meaning without pretending that the café itself is ancient.

Haven should embody six principles:

1. **Hospitality before spectacle.** The guest is received, oriented and invited to stay; Omani coffee culture and the majlis are living practices, not props.
2. **Routes rather than purity.** Dhofari identity is rooted and distinctive precisely while participating in movement across the sea.
3. **Local agency.** Indigenous Dhofaris, mountain producers, fishers and town communities made the system; they were not passive recipients of foreign civilisation.
4. **Many kinds of traveller.** Merchant, pilgrim, sailor, fisher, scholar, migrant worker, family and forced migrant must not be merged into one romantic “voyager.”
5. **Evidence with humility.** Say “may indicate” when scholarship is uncertain. Imported pottery proves exchange more readily than it proves ethnicity.
6. **Reciprocity.** People whose knowledge, music, recipes, stories or craft create the experience should approve its use, be credited and be paid.

The desired visitor feeling is: **“I came for the coast and coffee; I left understanding that Dhofar has always faced outward without ceasing to be itself.”**

4. A practical experience system

Always present, low-operational-load

- **The Routes Table:** one beautiful, accurate Indian Ocean map beneath glass or on a wall, showing Dhofar's land-to-sea connections and four time layers. QR links lead to sources and longer bilingual stories.
- **Object of the Month:** a licensed image or replica—ceramic sherd, bead, rope knot, incense grading tool, fishing implement, shipping seal—interpreted in 100 words and reviewed by an adviser. Never display an antiquity without legal provenance and approval.
- **The Arrivals Board:** “What is passing Raysut today?” Use public, legally reusable shipping information or a Port of Salalah partnership; pair one modern route with an older route. Avoid real-time operational detail if the port objects on security grounds.
- **Five-minute route cards:** Sumhuram—India, al-Baleed—East Africa, Zafar's horse trade, Mirbat—the interior and modern container Raysut. Arabic leads; English follows. Community-approved Shahri/Shehri, Mehri or Swahili audio can add voices without using endangered or minority languages as ornament.
- **A small reading shelf:** accessible Arabic and English works by Dhofari writers, archaeologists and Indian Ocean historians, plus children's books and a source guide.
- **Menu provenance:** a few dishes or drinks can tell documented routes, but with honest labels. Coffee should not be presented as a drink served at ancient Sumhuram. A “Monsoon Tasting Flight” can instead compare a Dhofari ingredient, an East African note and a South Asian technique as a contemporary collaboration.

Weekly and monthly programming

- **Harbour Table:** a monthly paid conversation with a fisher, retired sailor, port worker, archaeologist, boat builder, trader, musician or return-migrant family.
- **Fisher's Breakfast:** an early recurring event tied to responsible local catch, sea conditions and working-coast stories; designed with fishers rather than merely about them.

- **Routes Supper:** a limited-seat chef/resident collaboration tracing one defensible connection—Dhofar–Hadramawt, Dhofar–Malabar or Oman–Zanzibar—with the collaborator named and paid.
- **Listening Coast:** intimate, properly licensed sessions explaining a maritime song tradition or work rhythm. Al-Bar'ah may be included as Dhofari intangible heritage but should not be falsely described as a seafaring form. [UNESCO, Al-Bar'ah](#)
- **Children's Port Lab:** map monsoon winds, identify materials, tie safe knots, design cargo marks and interview a grandparent. The learning goal is connection, not costume.
- **Story Collection Days:** record memories of Raysut beach, landing fish, older dhows, port construction, migration and Khareef, using written consent, contributor control and archival standards.
- **Seasonal micro-exhibition:** one rigorously researched theme every three or four months rather than permanent faux-museum décor.

Excursions and destination links

- Package a **“Ports of Dhofar” day** with a licensed guide: Haven orientation and breakfast; al-Baleed/Museum of the Frankincense Land; Khor Rori/Sumhuram; Mirbat; return to Haven for a closing tasting or talk.
- Develop a short, permission-based **Raysut Working Coast Walk** linking Osara's public beach story, a safe view of modern shipping and, when completed and agreed, interpretation of the fishing harbour. It must not imply access to secure port areas.
- Offer an **Ocean Routes Passport** stamped at partner sites and businesses. Rewards should be learning or a small local product, not discounts that devalue partners.
- Create hotel and tour-operator versions for winter cultural visitors and smaller Khareef versions for high-volume domestic/GCC guests.

5. Why the Ministry and public partners may care

The concept directly serves declared national aims. Oman Vision 2040 calls for heritage to be preserved, documented and diffused internationally, for mutual understanding and coexistence, and for sustainable investment in heritage, culture and arts to contribute to economic development. [Oman Vision 2040, People and Society](#)

The Ministry has stated that tourism growth should create high-value experiences that respect cultural and environmental heritage and benefit local communities; it targets 12 million visitors by 2040. [Ministry of Heritage and Tourism, April 2025](#)

Haven can offer the Ministry:

- a private-sector interpretation pilot with low capital risk;
- an experience linking a World Heritage story to a contemporary working port;
- dwell time and visitor spending without construction inside an archaeological site;
- year-round cultural programming beyond Khareef scenery;
- youth and SME participation at an already supported Omani-led Osara destination;
- paid opportunities for guides, fishers, artists, writers, makers and food producers;
- a western Salalah/Raysut node that disperses visitors beyond the usual heritage circuit;
- measurable evidence about what residents and tourists actually engage with.

The initial request should be modest: **technical guidance, an adviser, permissions to reproduce approved material, introductions to site teams, and evaluation of a six-month pilot.** Do not ask the Ministry to validate an ambitious “maritime heritage centre” before Haven proves scholarship, community support, operational reliability and demand.

6. Connection to Osara and Raysut coastal development

Osara is a youth-led destination begun in 2022. In 2025 it expanded sea-view areas, open seating, restaurants and cafés with support from Dhofar Municipality, the SME Development Authority and Port of Salalah. [Oman News Agency, Osara project](#)

The Raysut fishing port project was reported 81% complete in January 2026. It includes a 610 m breakwater, fixed wharf, boat ramp, internal road, drainage, dredging and reclaimed working land. Its stated purpose is to support local fishers and fishing activity, not to create a tourist attraction. [Oman News Agency, January 2026](#)

Haven should therefore propose a complementary cultural layer, not annex the harbour symbolically:

- Work with Osara on a common public-realm story and event calendar so multiple cafés do not duplicate shallow “heritage nights.”
- Ask Dhofar Municipality to explore safe pedestrian links, shade, coastal signage and a viewpoint—not access to working quays.
- Ask fisheries authorities and fisher representatives what tourism would help or disrupt.
- Invite Port of Salalah to support an arrivals display, employee oral histories, school sessions or a maritime careers day through its community/ESG work.
- Establish a visible beach and water stewardship programme. Raysut has industrial, fishing and visitor uses in close proximity; environmental credibility must be earned through monitoring, clean-ups with appropriate authorities, waste prevention and honest reporting.
- Make the contrast itself interpretive: **ancient aromatic cargo, living fishery, modern container, future low-carbon port.**

7. Challenges and responses

Challenge	Why it matters	Practical response
Heritage becomes décor	Dhows, maps and incense can produce a generic Gulf theme with little truth.	Appoint a paid scholarly adviser and community council; publish sources; review every historical claim.
Romantic “cosmopolitanism”	Trade included power, hierarchy, slavery and unequal mobility.	Use separate, carefully facilitated interpretation; do not make suffering a menu theme or entertainment.
Claims about ethnicity exceed evidence	Objects, language, ancestry and self-identity are different evidence.	Describe encounters and communities precisely; avoid racial percentages or claims of descent without research.
Community extraction	Elders, artists and fishers can be used for content without benefit.	Consent, credit, fees, usage terms, transcript return and a right to withdraw sensitive material.
Café operations become overloaded	Events can damage speed, product quality and resident loyalty.	One fixed programme night at first; separate producer/curator role; measure service impact.
Seasonal tourism	Khareef can hide weak normal-period demand.	Resident membership, school activity, morning fisher/port-worker offer and winter heritage itineraries.
Industrial/security constraints	Port and fishing operations are not public stages.	Interpret from public space; obtain permissions; never promise secure access or publish sensitive data.
Coastal hazards and pollution	Khareef surf, cyclones, erosion, waste and industrial incidents affect safety and trust.	Seasonal operating plans, evacuation and weather thresholds, resilient movable displays, environmental partners.
Cultural performance is decontextualised	A dance or song at a café can become spectacle.	Performer-led explanation, appropriate setting, fair fee, photography rules and community control.
Weak commercial case	Cultural ambition can consume cash without repeat visits.	Pilot reversible formats; track event contribution, repeat rate and partner referrals before building space.
Brand confusion	“Museum café” can sound formal or tourist-only.	Keep the promise simple: excellent coastal café, one meaningful story each visit.

8. Growth path from coffee shop to cultural institution

Stage 1 — Evidence and trust (0–3 months)

- Form a five-to-seven-person paid advisory circle: Dhofari historian/archaeologist, fisher or maritime worker, local cultural practitioner, educator, community representative and Haven operator.
- Complete 20 recorded scoping interviews, not yet public.
- Audit names, visual symbols, menu claims and existing dhow imagery for accuracy.
- Prototype one Routes Table, five cards and one Harbour Table event.
- Establish consent, credit, safeguarding, licensing and fact-check procedures.

Gate: advisers approve the narrative; at least 70% of interviewed local participants consider it recognisable and respectful; café service does not deteriorate.

Stage 2 — Living Port pilot (4–9 months)

- Run six monthly Harbour Tables, three children's labs, two route suppers and one micro-exhibition.
- Launch a guided Ports of Dhofar itinerary with one licensed operator.
- Test hotel, school and Port of Salalah partnerships.
- Publish a small bilingual, sourced “Dhofar Faces the Ocean” booklet.

Gate: repeat resident participation, paid partner income, visitor satisfaction, referral traffic and positive independent scholarly review.

Stage 3 — Permanent programme (10–24 months)

- Design a flexible interpretation room or shaded pavilion only after the pilot proves use.
- Hire a part-time cultural producer/archivist.
- Build a bilingual digital oral-history and route archive with an appropriate repository partner.
- Establish an annual **Dhofar Ocean Week** across Haven, Osara and partner sites rather than trying to own the entire programme.
- Develop retail on consignment or revenue share: books, licensed prints, local craft, responsibly sourced frankincense, fishing/rope craft and collaborative food products.

Stage 4 — Recognised coastal node (2–5 years)

- Seek formal inclusion in cultural itineraries only after quality is demonstrable.
- Become a field-classroom and programme venue, not a collecting museum.
- Commission research and artist residencies on the connected Omani–Yemeni–African–Indian coast.
- Explore a social-enterprise arm or foundation if grants, archives and education become substantial; keep café accounts separate enough to know whether each activity is sustainable.

9. Follow-up investigation and conversations

Scholarship and evidence

1. Ask the Museum of the Frankincense Land and Directorate General of Heritage and Tourism in Dhofar for their current interpretive priorities, approved terminology and image-licensing route.
2. Interview the University of Pisa/Italian Mission to Oman team on Sumhuran and HAS1, specifically local–Hadrami interaction and the limits of the Indian-community evidence.
3. Interview the University of Naples L'Orientale team working at al-Baleed on urban daily life, imported materials and public interpretation.

4. Ask ArCHIAM and Mirbat stakeholders what elements of the 2016 heritage plan remain active and what visitor activity would benefit the old town.
5. Commission a Dhofari scholar to produce an Arabic-first annotated chronology and place-name guide.
6. Commission specialist reviews on Modern South Arabian languages, Afro-Omani cultural forms and the history of slavery before public programming.

Living communities

7. Hold separate listening sessions with Raysut fishers, port employees/retirees, women from coastal families, guides and youth; separate groups can reduce deference and improve candour.
8. Speak with Hadrami and Mahri families about cross-border family, food and language histories without assuming one political identity.
9. Invite Afro-Omani and Zanzibari-Omani cultural practitioners to define what they want represented and what they do not.
10. Include present-day Indian Ocean migrant residents as contemporary co-creators, not anonymous staff or ancient continuity symbols.
11. Ask local educators what children already learn about Sumhuram, al-Baleed, seafaring and Dhofar's languages, and where a field activity adds value.

Development and partnerships

12. Meet Osara's founders on shared destination identity, programme scheduling, signage, power/noise, waste and visitor flow.
13. Meet Dhofar Municipality planning/public-realm staff on walking safety, shade, interpretation locations and the status of Raysut coastal plans.
14. Meet the Ministry of Agriculture, Fisheries and Water Resources and local fisher representatives before proposing any fishing-port visitor element.
15. Meet Port of Salalah community/ESG and communications teams about oral histories, public shipping interpretation, school outreach and sponsorship boundaries.
16. Test the Ports of Dhofar itinerary with five licensed guides, five hotels and two cruise/ground handlers; ask what guests misunderstand and what timing is commercially workable.
17. Approach Oman Tourism College, Sultan Qaboos University and Dhofar University for student research, interpretation and hospitality placements.
18. Explore OMRAN's community-centred and SME programmes as models; OMRAN explicitly links tourism to cultural heritage, local supply chains and community enterprise. [OMRAN Sustainability and Legacy](#)

Questions that must be answered before capital expenditure

19. Which three stories do Dhofaris most want visitors to understand?
20. Which stories are sensitive, family-owned, sacred, gendered or inappropriate for a commercial venue?
21. Can Haven name and pay a credible curator/producer?
22. Does a cultural event increase repeat visits and food attachment after all direct costs?
23. Can a normal-month resident programme survive without Khareef volume?
24. What permissions apply to public events, tours, signage, imagery, amplified music and any use of Ministry/site names?
25. What physical coastal development is actually approved, funded and scheduled around Osara/Raysut, as distinct from ideas or press coverage?

10. Measures of meaning and viability

Haven should report a small balanced scorecard quarterly:

- percentage of public claims reviewed and sourced;
- number and value of paid local collaborators;
- contributor consent and satisfaction;
- resident versus visitor attendance and repeat attendance;
- school/guide/hotel/heritage-site referrals;
- event contribution after performer, curator and staffing costs;
- café wait time and guest satisfaction on programme nights;
- Arabic and English use, accessibility and community-approved language content;
- local procurement and retail revenue returned to makers;
- waste per guest, clean-up outcomes and documented environmental incidents;
- corrections requested and corrections published.

The Ministry case becomes persuasive when Haven can show that the project produces **knowledge, local income, longer and more dispersed visitor itineraries, resident pride and environmental care** while remaining operationally sound.

Conclusion

Dhofar's maritime heritage is not a single golden age. It is a long succession of coastal cultures: an indigenous Dhofari base; Hadrami settlement and negotiation at Sumhuram; Islamic urban life and international commerce at al-Baleed; Mirbat and smaller harbour networks; movement through the Yemeni coast, India, Africa and beyond; unequal and sometimes forced migrations; modern national integration; and the high-speed container world of Raysut.

Haven can continue that history only by continuing its **social function**. It should become a place of safe arrival, exchange, listening and return. The café is not an obstacle to cultural meaning: hospitality is the medium that can make scholarship public and encounter natural. But meaning will come from repeated relationships, paid local voices, accurate interpretation and stewardship—not from nautical decoration.

The most credible first move is therefore small: establish the advisory circle, conduct the interviews, produce one reviewed map and host one excellent Harbour Table. If those acts feel true to local people and useful to visitors, Haven has the foundation of a destination—and eventually of a cultural institution.

Selected scholarly and policy reading

- Alessandra Avanzini and the Italian Mission to Oman, Khor Rori/Sumhuram research; entry point: [University of Pisa—Indian community investigation](#).
- Silvia Lischi, [“A First Definition of the Dhofar Coastal Culture”](#).
- Daniele Zampierin et al., [“A multi-analytical approach applied to pottery from Oman”](#).
- Juris Zarins and Lynne S. Newton, [Dhofar Through the Ages](#).
- Alexia Pavan, [“The Islamic Port of al-Balid \(Oman\), between Land and Sea”](#).
- J. E. Peterson, [“Oman's Diverse Society: Southern Oman”](#).
- Steffen Wippel, [“Salalah: The Economic Development and Spatial Fragmentation of a Globalized Port City”](#).
- Roxani Eleni Margariti, [Aden and the Indian Ocean Trade](#).
- Engseng Ho, [The Graves of Tarim](#).
- A. V. Sedov, [“New archaeological and epigraphical material from Qana”](#).

- UNESCO, [Land of Frankincense](#) and [sustainable-tourism case study](#).
- Oman Vision 2040, [Citizenship, Identity and National Heritage and Culture](#).